This ideological flexibility allows populism to thrive across a range of political regimes, from established democracies to authoritarian systems. Leaders as diverse as Venezuela's Hugo Chávez, the United States' Donald Trump, and Turkey's Recep Tayyip Erdoğan exemplify populism's adaptability. Often, populists come to power through democratic means, only to implement illiberal reforms once in office, as seen in the leadership of Brazil's Jair Bolsonaro and Hungary's Viktor Orbán.

Central to populism is a deep distrust of elites—often including scientists, technocrats, and bureaucrats—who are seen as out of touch with the experiences and priorities of ordinary people (Carnegie, Clark, and Zucker 2024). Populists challenge these experts' authority to "formulate truth claims," prioritizing practical knowledge and lived experience over formal education and specialized expertise (Rigney 1991, 447). This skepticism often extends to international bodies, like the United Nations, World Trade Organization, and International Criminal Court, which populists accuse of using expertise as a tool for exploitation (Brewer 2016).

This anti-elite sentiment resonates strongly with populist constituents. Supporters often feel neglected by traditional governance structures and turn to populist leaders as champions of their concerns (Rico, Guinjoan, and Anduiza 2017). Economic anxiety, perceived loss of status, and frustrations over immigration frequently fuel this alignment (Malhotra, Margalit, and Mo 2013; Baccini and Weymouth 2021; Ballard-Rosa et al. 2021; Broz, Frieden, and Weymouth 2021). These grievances, coupled with a distrust of expert authorities, leave populist voters particularly susceptible to conspiracy theories and misinformation (Oliver and Wood 2014; Oliver and Rahn 2016). Populist leaders exploit these tendencies, manipulating narratives and denying inconvenient facts to strengthen their appeal.

Populists' opposition to elites takes on a special significance when it comes to IOs, which are often staffed by the very technocrats and experts they vilify. For populist leaders, IOs represent not only a repository of elite influence but also a direct threat to national sovereignty. These leaders often frame IOs as meddling institutions that impose foreign agendas and undermine the will of their domestic constituencies. By attacking global elites, populists position themselves as the authentic voice of ordinary citizens, amplifying their appeal at home (Wajner 2022).